Vayaishev 5784

ר' מאיר מפרמישלאן – some of my ancestors come from פרמישלאן. As I've mentioned in previous talks, my עלטער, עלטער, עלטער – I don't know exactly how many generations back – was a שוחט in פרמישלאן. This was a very בכבוד'דיג position. (I'm not sure if it was at the same time as ר' מאיר. I doubt it. I assume it was afterward, as it's still within the recollection of the previous דור, and ר' מאיר lived a couple of hundred years ago).

I have a story in a מעשה ביכול about ר' מאיר, and I want to use this מעשה to make a point about the פרשה. In the times of ר' מאיר, Jews found it difficult to make ends meet, but they managed as best as they could – the story of all of our generations. Sometimes, however, people couldn't resist an opportunity to make a fast buck. The ראש הקהל, the official leader of the Jewish community, once secured a lucrative contract with the army to supply tobacco. Seeing a golden opportunity, he decided to substitute sawdust or other fillers in some of the sacks and collect the payment at the rate for tobacco - not a nice thing to do.

This went on for some time until he heard that an inspector was coming to audit his transactions, certain to expose his fraud. Panic-stricken, he rushed to ר' מאיר for advice. It was Friday afternoon, and he couldn't see the רב until after שבת. On שבת morning, the ראש הקהל was honored when the רב called him up for ששי – the sixth עלייה – a position of respect in those times. However, he quickly realized that ר' מאיר was not someone who you could pull something over.

The רב was also the בעל קורא and read the תורה himself each week. At the end of ששי, he stopped three פסוקים before the usual end of the עלייה. The פסוק where he paused was (39:20): וַיִּקַּח אֲדֹנֵי יוֹסֵף אֹתוֹ וַיִּתְּנֵהוּ אֶל בֵּית הַסֹּהַר מְקוֹם אֲשֶׁר אֲסִירֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ אֲסוּרִים וַיְהִי שָׁם בְּבֵית הַסֹּהַר. This pasuk describes how פוטיפר imprisoned יוסף over an alleged crime. The ראש הקהל understood immediately – the רב was hinting at his punishment, implying that his fate, too, was to be imprisoned for his deceitful actions. The רב motioned for him to recite the ברכה and conclude the עלייה, but the ראש הקהל refused, signaling to the רב to continue and stop at the usual פסוק (39:23): אֵין שַׂר בֵּית הַסֹּהַר רֹאֶה אֶת כָּל מְאוּמָה בְּיָדוֹ בַּאֲשֶׁר ה' אִתּוֹ וַאֲשֶׁר הוּא עֹשֶׂה ה' מַצְלִיחַ – that in all that Yosef did, he succeeded with Hashem's help. The ראש הקהל wanted the ר' מאיר to stop at this pasuk, as he felt that he needed this ברכה. Finally, ר' מאיר relented, and continued the leining and stopped at the correct place.

After שבת, ר' מאיר summoned the ראש הקהל and admonished him sternly. He explained the gravity of his actions, warning him that he could endanger the entire Jewish community by stealing from the government. The ראש הקהל accepted the rebuke, promising to act more responsibly in the future. The following day, the inspector informed the ראש הקהל that his audit was postponed due to being reassigned to another area.

The last פסוק of the פרשה is (40:23) וְלֹא זָכַר שַׂר הַמַּשְׁקִים אֶת יוֹסֵף וַיִּשְׁכָּחֵהוּ, which actually is appropriate to this story. The שר המשקים forgot about יוסף, despite the kindness יוסף had shown him. This פסוק reflects a lack of הכרת הטוב, gratitude, on the part of the שר המשקים. Not only did he forget the בְּשׂוֹרָה טוֹבָה that יוסף gave him, but he also disregarded the חיזוק and support יוסף had provided. This is a very good פסוק for people in trouble who are being attacked by someone, it can be used as a תפילה that the pursuers "forget" about them and move on to a different focus. I personally recite both of these פסוקים (39:23 & 40:23) regularly - sometimes daily, sometimes weekly - along with other פסוקים, and Im Yirtzeh Hashem these pesukim can help us in an עת צרה. The best thing to do in an עת צרה is to keep in mind to אֵין עוֹד מִלְבַדּוֹ, which I've said to you before, and I still believe and hold very shtark, is the right answer for all of our צרות. All the efforts we make - whether for ourselves, our communities, or ארץ ישראל - will only succeed if הקדוש ברוך הוא chooses to use them as His שליח. Everything comes from Him, and our role is to focus on תשובה, and that, in turn should cause Hashem to bring about our ultimate ישועה and גאולה שלמה.

https://youtu.be/2AbXXwZip04